

Beyond smart watches and rings

Wearable Patches might be the next big thing in health tracking

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Smartwatches have made health tracking mainstream, while smart rings have offered a more discreet way to monitor sleep, activity and recovery. The next step can be wearables that do away with both the watch face and the ring altogether. We have already talked about the Temple wearable, which can track blood flow and tell you about stress levels in different situations. But there can be more devices too.

A newly granted patent from Oura hints at this possibility. The company seems to be working on a wearable patch that can monitor blood oxygen levels and sleeping position to watch out for different types of sleep apnoea. The concept is interesting and definitely different from the devices that we already know. Instead of trying to fit more sensors and health features into a device worn on the finger, Oura seems to be exploring a form factor designed around a more specific health-monitoring task.

Why Oura might be looking beyond smart rings

Wearables have traditionally competed on convenience. Smartwatches offer screens, notifications and health tracking, while smart rings appeal to people who want many of those measurements without wearing a watch throughout the day. Both form factors, however, have practical limitations when it comes to monitoring particular physiological signals.

A ring is well suited to collecting certain measurements from the finger, including changes in heart rate and blood oxygenation. But sleep-related breathing problems can involve several variables, and understanding